

Your social feed is the EU's new battleground

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING. I'm Gabriel Gavin, back with you for the last day of this week. Thanks to those who wrote in with suggestions for Europe's most powerful left-hander — and congratulations to Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever for winning the accolade.

In today's Playbook:

- Why influencers are key to Brussels' plan to beat disinformation.
- Five top spots for a meal in the sun, for those in Brussels this weekend.
- Faces in the crowd: Maximilian Krah, Sevim Aktas, Ursula von der Leyen, Glenn Micallef, Isabella Tovaglieri, Stefan De Keersmaecker, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, Angelina Eichhorst, Adalbert Johns and more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender podcast: We're bringing back an archive episode in which Sarah and Laurens ask former MEP Marietje Schaake whether Europe really has what it takes to quit American Big Tech.

DRIVING THE DAY

PLEASE SUBSCRIBE: The EU is embracing influencers in an effort to claw back ground in an online information environment increasingly hostile to Brussels, placing pro-European voices into feeds where anti-EU narratives are thriving, three officials told Playbook.

Getting involved: "If the objective is to create a pro-democratic, pro-European environment, then we need to tap into these resources," Sevim Aktas, an Instagram influencer employed by Youth Commissioner Glenn Micallef, told my colleague Sebastian Starcevic.

Why now: Brussels can't afford to be absent from the digital platforms where millions of people — especially under-30s — increasingly get their news and views, according to two of the people working on the initiative, granted anonymity to discuss the strategy. That's particularly true when countries including China, Russia and Iran are known to target the same demographic around elections, they said.

Siege mentality: “The European information space is under siege from authoritarian actors from all sides,” said Saman Nazari, coordinator of the Counter Disinformation Network at democracy-defense nonprofit Alliance4Europe. The EU, he said, is an attractive target because while it symbolizes “European unity and liberal democracy,” many citizens have relatively little understanding of how its institutions work.

Serious business: In a sign of the priority being given to the push, two prominent former spokespersons, Adalbert Jahnz and Stefan De Keersmaecker, have been put in charge of overseeing the outreach inside the Commission.

#Europe: Instagram and TikTok stars will again be invited to Commission President Ursula von der Leyen’s State of the EU speech in Strasbourg next month. That’s on top of a push inside the European Council to bring influencers in to cover summits later this year and a long-standing working relationship between Parliament and digital creators .

Proof of concept: Aktas said Micallef’s following rose from around 5,000 when she joined his office to more than 19,000, having had seemingly mixed success with policy content, travelogs, birthday posts and more playful campaigns aimed at reaching people outside the Brussels bubble.

The TikTok paradox: The Commission prohibits TikTok on staff devices and doesn’t maintain an official account, yet it’s increasingly working through independent creators who do use the platform. Asked about that tension, a Commission spokesperson said the EU executive “engages with content creators to effectively communicate with citizens at large and foster open and transparent communication.”

Not everyone is convinced: One EU official argued that some commissioners’ enthusiasm for social media owes less to the information battle than to their policy portfolios’ light workload. “Some in this College have so little to do that they can spend time trying to be celebrities,” they said. The Commission declined to comment ...

But like it or loathe it, the EU’s foray into your phone screen is happening — making social media influencing the latest in a long line of sectors that Brussels sees as strategically important.

BIG AND BREAKING

IRAN WAR WATCH: The Trump administration has turned up the temperature on Tehran, with Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth saying the U.S. can maintain a naval blockade indefinitely and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent hinting at sweeping new measures to isolate Iran economically. Reuters has more .

THE HARDEST JOB IN TOWN: Volodymyr Zelenskyy needs to find a new Washington envoy to deal with Donald Trump — but nobody seems to want the job , writes Jamie Dettmer.

ROBOT WARS: AI might fly the drones, but NATO will depend on humans to decide who they target , according to new reporting from Luca-Marie Hoffmann and Jake Epstein this morning.

CORK POPPED: Prominent German far-right politician Maximilian Krah faces arrest over an unpaid legal bill of less than €300 , after his failed attempt to sue a comedian in a dispute over champagne. Krah says he wasn’t aware of the outstanding bill.

TIDE'S OUT: Romania has shut down its last operating nuclear reactor after water levels in the Danube River fell too low to supply its cooling systems ... while the drought has forced Hungary to reconsider its Russian-backed expansion of the Paks nuclear power plant .

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

BURNING ISSUE: France's firefighters are demanding better working conditions and resources as they dig into fight massive wildfires.

ARE YOU A SNEAKY AI USER? Those artificially edited selfies are going to be a lot easier to spot when EU rules on the "watermarking" of content come into effect .

GREENWASHING BACKSLIDE: The EU's framework for preventing companies falsely claiming their products are green and clean only goes so far, Marianne Gros writes.

CAN'T GET A DAY OFF: A string of crises affecting Europe is landing at the worst possible time — just when top politicians and officials are trying to catch a break , writes Aitor Hernández-Morales.

GOOD EVENING, EUROPE: Eurovision 2027 will be held in Burgas , on Bulgaria's Black Sea coast.

AOC SOLIDARITY: Isabella Tovaglieri, an MEP from Italy's anti-immigration League party, says that, like U.S. Representative Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, she has frozen her eggs. "Women's fertility has no political color," the lawmaker told La Repubblica .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny. High of 36C.

IT'S AL FRESCO, NOT AL DESKO: The weather is warm, your colleagues are away ... and if you find yourself stuck manning the phones in Brussels, you may as well take yourself for a nice lunch in a restaurant garden somewhere. Here's a list of some of the best green spaces to kick back with a fancy meal, while weather permits ...

Sale e Pepe: This Italian spot just up the road from the Schuman Roundabout opened earlier this year but has quickly become a Playbook favorite for affordable antipasti and seafood linguini, with a tiny open kitchen and ingredients brought in fresh from the Bel Paese. Take a table out back and enjoy the sunshine, while it lasts.

The Twelve: Come September, the upmarket restaurant in the courtyard garden at the Thon Hotel on Rue de la Loi will be heaving with visiting diplomats. But while Brussels is still quiet, you'll have no problem getting a spot to sample dishes like Mechelen cuckoo chicken fillet with Bintje potato mousseline.

La Brasserie des Étang Mellaerts: This beautiful scenic eatery in Woluwe-Saint-Pierre has been the venue for some controversial meetings, but boasts an extensive menu of traditional Belgian cuisine for those further out from the European Quarter, including croquettes, offal and steaks.

BRUGMANN Restaurant: Just off Place Brugmann, this exclusive-feeling garden oasis offers white tablecloths, an impressive wine cellar and fine dining dishes — as well as a selection of caviars served with Grey Goose Vodka for anyone looking for a more lavish summer evening.

Atelier Acqua e Sale: The second Italian spot on this list has a tiny, intimate garden under the trees in Châtelain and is featured in the Michelin Guide for favorites like vitello tonnato and more refined versions of classics, like anchovy and fior di latte ravioli with pistachio pesto and prawns. They're on break but reopen Aug. 26.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is holding a cabinet retreat later this month to get his mojo back , after a difficult cabinet reshuffle and disputes over pensions and tax.

London: As Westminster focuses on the fate of Nigel Farage in the Clacton by-election, Andy Burnham is continuing his listening tour of England.

Washington PM: Wisconsin's gubernatorial candidate David Crowley has a plan to unite the state's Democrats : opposing "MAGA extremism."

BIRTHDAYS

Euronews' Ma de La Baume; French High Commissioner for Strategy and Planning Clément Beaune; EU Ambassador to Egypt and the League of Arab States Angelina Eichhorst; Sanofi's Agata Pawenta; NYT's Katrin Bennhold.

Celebrating Saturday: MEPs Isabel Serra Sánchez, Carla Tavares and Monika Beňová; former MEPs Valter Flego, Pedro Silva Pereira, James Carver and Edward McMillan-Scott; former French PM Alain Juppé; POLITICO's Izabela Kantor; EUIPO's Yassen Gyurov; European Commission's Simon O'Connor. Liechtenstein National Day.

Celebrating Sunday: Former MEPs Tomasz Frankowski, Lorenzo Cesa and Diane Dodds; commentator Paul Taylor.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producer Dean Southwell.

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